

World in Brief: Qatar reports “progress” after separate America-Iran talks; Russia strikes Kyiv



Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

A Qatari spokesman said separate meetings with **American** and **Iranian** negotiators in Doha made “positive progress”. He said further talks would be planned after the funeral of Ali Khamenei, Iran’s former supreme leader, which begins this weekend. Earlier J.D. Vance, America’s vice-president, agreed that discussions were going well, but warned that Donald Trump had “a lot of options” if Iran did not comply with [America’s terms for peace](#).

Russia launched missiles and drones on **Kyiv**, setting buildings ablaze and killing at least 13 people. Several people were reported trapped under rubble. Russia has ramped up its attacks as Ukraine has been conducting its own drone campaign against Russia’s energy infrastructure. Separately, German prosecutors charged a Ukrainian with blowing up [undersea pipelines](#) that carry Russian natural gas into Germany. The Ukrainian government has denied involvement.

Rather than renew **America’s trade pact** with **Canada** and **Mexico** for 16 years, the Trump administration said it would pursue separate deals with its neighbours. Mr Trump has soured on what he once called “the [best agreement](#) we’ve ever made”, which he

negotiated during his first term. The deal will be reviewed annually until it expires in 2036, unless one of the countries withdraws.

Mr Trump dismissed criticism of his [cryptocurrency profits](#). Financial disclosures revealed the president earned more than \$1bn from his crypto ventures last year. The profits were driven by sales of his meme coin, \$TRUMP, and deals linked to his family's crypto firm, World Liberty Financial. Mr Trump, who has aggressively promoted the deregulation of cryptocurrencies, denied a conflict of interest. He said external institutions run his finances.

Japan's weak currency caused 45 firms to go bankrupt during the first half of 2026, the highest number since 2022. [The yen](#) has sunk to a 40-year low against the dollar, driving up import costs and squeezing profit margins. Wholesalers with limited pricing power were most affected. Satsuki Katayama, the country's finance minister, vowed to take "decisive steps" with America's Treasury to prop up the currency.

Meta's share price rose by 9%, following reports that it is starting a cloud-computing business that will sell surplus data-centre capacity. Like many tech giants, the firm has been [splurging](#) in an effort to win the AI race; it expects to spend \$145bn on AI infrastructure this year alone. Meta's new business will help it defray some of that cost.

England squeezed past a stubborn Democratic Republic of Congo, to reach the last 16 of the **World Cup**. Harry Kane, England's captain, scored two second-half goals to secure his side's 2-1 win. They will now play Mexico, the co-hosts, in Mexico City. Meanwhile America, another co-host, booked their place in the next round after beating Bosnia and Herzegovina 2-0 in Santa Clara.

Figure of the day: 2.7%, the percentage of GDP that Britain now aims to commit to defence spending by 2029, a rise of just 0.1%

over next year's target. [Read about the country's defence-budget bind.](#)

US in Brief: Refilling the swamp



Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump said his extraordinary **financial windfall** in 2025 was thanks to a booming stock market, which meant “everybody’s profiting.” Democrats were less convinced. Adam Schiff, a Californian senator, wrote on social media that “In the first year of his presidency, Trump made more money than in the rest of his life combined...This is the cost of corruption.” Financial disclosures revealed the president made at least \$2.2bn [in outside income](#) in 2025. The president said external institutions, whom he “never” speaks to, run his finances. The White House denied any conflicts of interest.

Two federal judges in Massachusetts and Washington, DC struck down the Trump administration’s proposed overhaul of **student-loan forgiveness**. Public-service workers are currently eligible for [debt relief](#); the administration wanted to forbid it to those whose employers are deemed to have a “substantial illegal purpose”. More than 20 states argued the overhaul could target organisations that are at odds with the Trump administration, such as those supporting transgender health care.

The Justice Department sued **California** and **Virginia** over separate [gun restrictions](#) that came into effect on Wednesday. Virginia’s law bans the sale and manufacture of some semi-automatic firearms; California’s prohibits purchases of a type of

pistol that can be converted to shoot automatically. The DoJ accused each state of violating the Second Amendment.

Ahead of America's semiquincentennial **Micron**, a memory-chip maker, said it would invest \$250m in "[Trump Accounts](#)", the president's investment accounts for children, which will become available from July 4th. Mr Trump claimed it was "the BIGGEST CORPORATE investment of its kind". Last week Micron reported record quarterly earnings of \$41.5bn, fuelled by the AI boom. In December Michael Dell, a tech billionaire, pledged \$6.25bn towards Trump Accounts.

Mr Trump took his first trip on a luxury jet given to America by Qatar. He accepted the Boeing 747 after complaining about the shabbiness of the two existing **Air Force One** planes, prompting some lawmakers to complain that the Gulf country was seeking to buy influence. The president's new toy has had a \$400m refit, including a paint job similar to his personal jet.

The EU wins a long antitrust battle with Google



Photograph: Alamy

As expected, the European Court of Justice upheld a €4.1bn (\$4.7bn) fine against Google on Thursday for reinforcing its dominant position in search by illegally tying it to other services in its Android mobile operating system. The appeal dated back to 2018, when the European Commission ruled that the Alphabet-owned company had behaved anticompetitively against smartphone makers and mobile-phone operators. It blamed Google for forcing Android devices to provide all of the company's services, including its search engine, as a condition for installing its app store. In 2022 a lower court cut the fine from €4.3bn to €4.1bn.

The original verdict exemplified Europe's crackdown on big-tech firms at a time when American antitrust enforcement was supine. Big tech firms argue that European trustbusters remain overzealous; Google says its policies help consumers. The fine is the biggest antitrust penalty ever. Still, Alphabet can shoulder the sum, which amounts to just a tenth or so of its operating cashflow last quarter.

How to win friends in the Caucasus



Photograph: Getty Images

The south Caucasus is caught between big, bullying neighbours. Iran, Russia and Turkey have long vied for influence there. But recently the European Union's role has grown. Azerbaijan has become an important supplier of natural gas to the bloc. Meanwhile, Armenia, Azerbaijan's long-time rival, has been pivoting away from Russia and strengthening ties with the West. On Thursday Ursula von der Leyen, the president of the European Commission, arrived in Armenia, fresh from a stop in Azerbaijan.

Mrs von der Leyen praised Armenia's prime minister, Nikol Pashinyan, for his efforts to make peace with Azerbaijan. Her biggest announcement was an offer of tariff-free access to the EU, which Armenia one day hopes to join, for 80% of the country's goods. For Mr Pashinyan, that is a boon: ahead of his re-election last month Russia banned imports of lots of Armenian products to weaken him. In a tough neighbourhood, he needs all the friends he can get.

The limits of Japan's and India's friendship

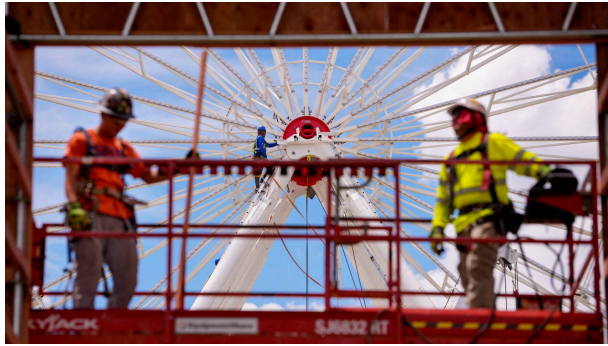


Illustration: David Simonds

In 2007 Japan's prime minister, Abe Shinzo, told India's parliament that the Indian and Pacific oceans were merging into a "confluence of the two seas". Japan's current leader, Takaichi Sanae, hopes to build upon her mentor's vision of an open Indo-Pacific. On Thursday she met Narendra Modi, her Indian counterpart, in New Delhi. Economic security was high on the agenda. The two countries also signed a pact to collaborate on AI and energy.

Anxiety about China has [pushed the two countries together](#). Ms Takaichi started a spat with China by suggesting that Japan might have no choice but to become involved if China attacked Taiwan. China retaliated by curbing exports to Japan. Meanwhile, Japanese investment in India is growing; a bullet train connecting Mumbai and Ahmedabad, now under construction, uses Japanese technology. Still, India is not a formal ally. It prizes "strategic autonomy" and remains close to Russia, a country on which Japan imposes sanctions because it invaded Ukraine. India and Japan are getting friendlier—but may never be truly close.

America's steady jobs engine



Photograph: Getty Images

Last year America's labour market looked to be running out of steam. Hiring slowed, and job growth was concentrated in health care. Now the [pace has picked up](#). Payrolls have risen by an average of 113,000 a month in 2026, and by 188,000 over the past three months. Hiring has also broadened into leisure and hospitality. For now, the labour market is purring along.

The next indication comes on Thursday, when America's Bureau of Labour Statistics releases its jobs report for June. Economists expect it to show that payrolls rose by 115,000 and that unemployment held steady at 4.3%. World Cup-related spending may provide an extra boost, particularly to hospitality. Data already released this week point the same way. ADP, a payroll-processing company, reported nearly 100,000 new private-sector jobs in May. Job openings have remained strong. For the Federal Reserve, that cuts two ways. A steady jobs market eases fears of a recession. It also gives policymakers less reason to cut rates.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Which Muppet helps children practise their mental arithmetic?

Wednesday: Arthur Wellesley, a British field marshal, is better known by his aristocratic title. What is it?

*Without words, without writing
and without books there would be
no history, there could be no
concept of humanity.*

Hermann Hesse